

The **GOCBS**

Newsletter

Next Meeting:
To Be Determined

Our Spring Bird Fair
and Our Spring Avian Clinic
Have Been Cancelled



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Our President's Letter

April 2020

Dear GOCBS Members,

Where do I begin to explain the hardship of this letter?

Last month we cancelled the meeting because of the concern of a virus going around. Then it changed to an all-out war to our nation. I was watching other closures of events and then put in motion the decision to cancel our fair. Our event was non-refundable so that was a costly decision.

To date nobody in my direct family has got the virus. It's a work in progress to keep updating our practices of personal hygiene to combat this bug. If you need help or become sick and can't care for your birds, let someone know. It may be a challenge to help so advance warning is greatly appreciated. Inform family members and relatives and have contact numbers available to ease this process. A letter of intent and directive to allow us, the club to care for your bird(s). I hope this does not happen and pray that all members of the bird community, family and friends be safe and healthy.

We are working on an app to have a meeting, more details to be announced.

There is no meeting this month.

Thank You,

Rick Kling,

President – GOCBS

Editor's Note

As everyone has heard over these last several weeks, public gatherings of more than 10 is forbidden in lieu of the COVID-19 Pandemic. Therefore, the Spring Fair which was scheduled for April 26th and our Spring Avian Clinic which was scheduled for May 3rd **HAVE BOTH BEEN CANCELLED.**

FURTHER, WE WILL NOT BE ACCEPTING SURRENDERED BIRDS AND ADOPTION OF BIRDS IS SUSPENDED UNTIL FURTHER NOTICE.

These measures are made to remain in compliance with governmental requirements and the CDC as we, as a Country, come together to slow down the spread or eradicate this Coronavirus (COVID-19) by limiting gatherings to 10 or less and distancing ourselves from others by at least six feet.

Please keep informed of this National Emergency by keeping abreast with local and National News.

We are experimenting with a teleconferencing App (ZOOM) in which we may conduct meetings via a smart device, an iPad, or computer (see Zoom Cloud Instructions on the following page). You will want to remain abreast of our Club President's decision by watching your e-mail for additional information.

Thank you for your support and please remember to donate to the GOCBS during the May 20 Omaha Gives (www.OmahaGives.org). We look forward to our Fall Fair and Avian Clinic.

Thank You,

G. Lavoie
Editor

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ZOOM Cloud Meetings Instructions

1. For the use of ZOOM Cloud Meetings, there is no need to create an account. Viewing a meeting can be done by selecting the meeting invite (hyper-link) received in your email.
2. If you are using a Smart Device, please follow steps 3 or 4 before clicking on the hyper-link in the meeting invite.
3. If using an Apple product, download the ZOOM Cloud Meetings app from the App Store. This will be needed if you will be using an iPhone or iPad.
4. If using a device that requires Google Play, you will want to download the ZOOM app from the Google Play Store.
5. If using a web browser on your computer, select the link and your computer should ask for the download and then start the meeting.
6. If the link does not work, go to Zoom.com and click **Join A Meeting**. Meeting ID number and password will be needed.
7. **Note about the club meeting.** We are using a free version of ZOOM Cloud Meetings, so we are limited to 40 minutes. Officers will give their reports and then a short meeting to follow. You can choose to have video on or off and microphone on or off. We will mute all lines to keep the meeting going because of the time limit. Any questions please email them to gocbsne@gmail.com.

There will be a test meeting to work out any questions for the club members
Sunday, April 5, at 3 pm.

This will be a **test meeting only** to sign on and leave
to make sure your connection is working.

Since our meeting will be limited to 40 minutes, we will have little time
on the meeting date to trouble shoot any connections.

Please look for the ZOOM invite in a couple of days in your email.

GREATER OMAHA CAGE BIRD SOCIETY

Who Needs a Bird Anyway?



If you keep birds as pets or raise them for a hobby . . .

. . . *YOU DO!!*

Bird clubs are great resources for anyone interested in keeping birds. All bird owners go through similar experiences, so the resources of information about a variety of subjects can be a big help.

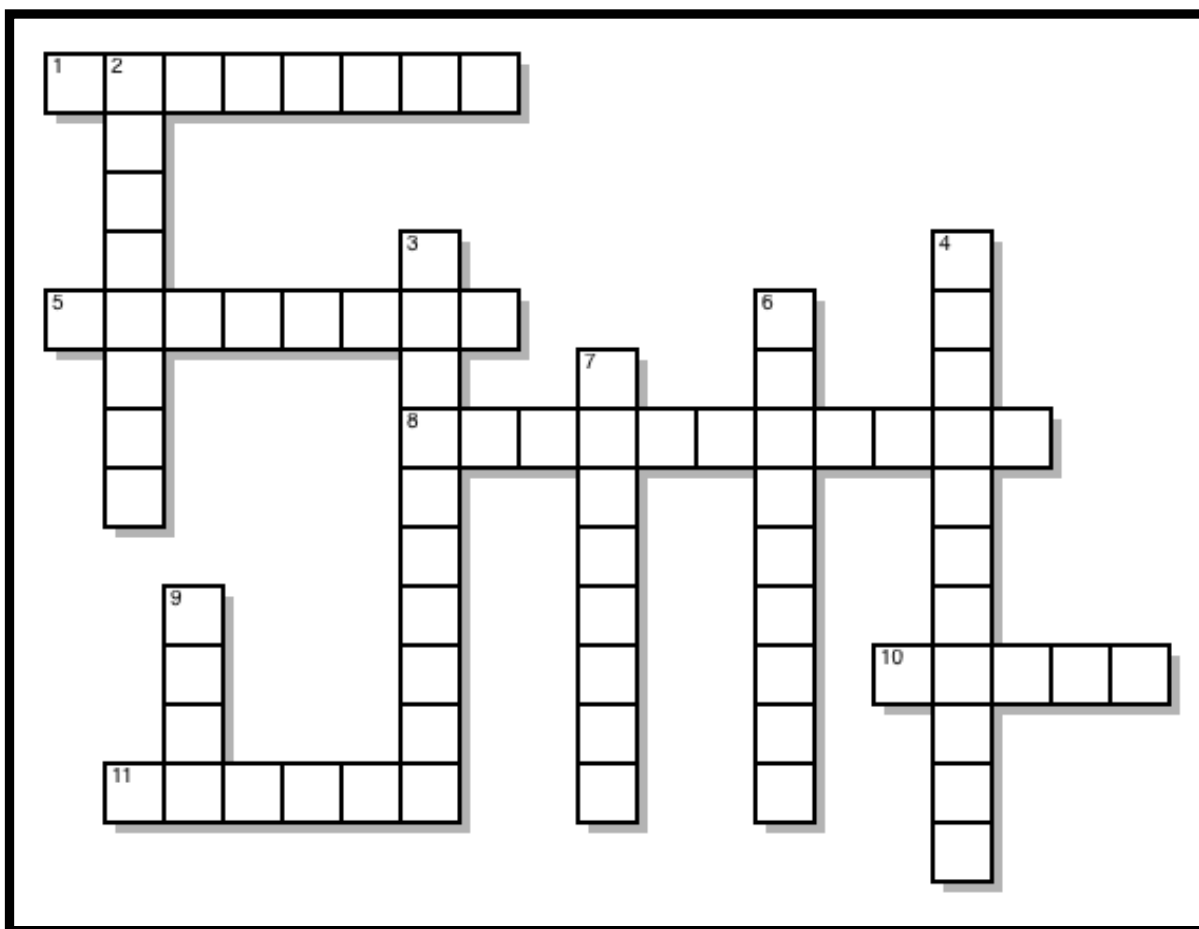
Club members can recommend places to buy your bird supplies, teach you how to hand-feed babies and refer you to a qualified avian veterinarian. Or, if you have had a lot of experience, you may be able to help share that type of information with someone who is just getting started.

Bird clubs can also keep you aware of current legislation that may affect which species of birds you may keep or how many. Clubs may have functions that would interest you, such as fairs, shows, swap meets, and clinics. Meetings may include guest speakers. Even if you join only to get the newsletters, you will be well informed! Another great benefit is you meet a lot of people with similar interests and some great, long-lasting friendships may evolve!



F U N C O R N E R

Smallest to Biggest to You Guess It



Across

- 1 Small Town on the Big Island
- 5 ____, Arizona
- 8 One of the largest cities in Russia
- 10 Largest City in Sq.Mi. in Alaska
- 11 ____, Arizona

Down

- 2 Largest City in Sq.Mi. in Montana
- 3 ____, Arkansas
- 4 Largest City in Sq.Mi. in Maine
- 6 Smallest Alaskan Town
- 7 Bonanza, ____ with Pop. of One
- 9 McMulle's Population

Ways to Donate to GOCBS Just Follow the Links

- Greater Omaha Cage Bird Society on Go Fund Me – see our website <http://www.GreaterOmahaCageBirdSociety.org> for further information.
- Log on to www.togetheragreatergood.com (TAGG) and follow these 4 steps.
 1. Download the free app: Together A Greater Good
 2. Visit participating businesses (there is a list on the website) and “TAGG” (track) your purchases.
 3. Choose which “Cause” to support (there is a list on the website). The business will donate to them.
 4. Share your good deed with others.
- Log on to www.smile.amazon.com. If you shop through Amazon, this is another way to give a donation to your favorite charity. Amazon will donate 0.05% of the price of your eligible AmazonSmile purchases to the charitable organization of your choice. AmazonSmile is the same Amazon you know with the same products, same prices, and same service.
- Log on to www.omahagives.org and follow these steps.
 1. Click on Find A Nonprofit.
 2. Click on Name, Keyword.
 3. Type in GOCBS and hit enter.
 4. Click on Give.
 5. Fill out the form and click on Add To Cart
 6. Click on Checkout and follow the instructions.

- If you wish to go directly to the GOCBS Omaha Gives page just click on this link.

<https://www.omahagives.org/index.php?section=organizations&action=overview&fwID=1298>

- Remember - You can also always donate directly to the club at the meetings or when you renew your membership.

**Remember!!! No matter how or when you donate, it is always
TAX DEDUCTABLE**

NOTICES AND REMINDERS	
➤	FOR PUBLIC HEALTH REASONING, THE APRIL MEETING, OUR SPRING BIRD FAIR AND SPRING AVIAN CLINIC HAVE BEEN CANCELLED.
➤	DUE TO COVID-19, ALL SURRENDERING AND/OR ADOPTION OF BIRDS ARE TEMPORARLY SUSPENDED UNTIL FURTHER NOTICE.
➤	If anyone has anything which needs to be mailed to the club you are asked to send it to: GOCBS, c/o Marcia Delehoy, 2832 Lucht Lane, Omaha, NE 68152.
➤	Please save your 'Family Fare' receipts and bring them to the meetings. Georgia C. is collecting them for the Bellevue Senior Center which in turn receives \$1,000 after accumulating \$150,000 in 'savings.' All this for a very good cause. Receipts must be the original.

Calendar of Events	
Next Meeting	To Be Determined
Spring Bird Fair	CANCELLED
Avian Clinic	CANCELLED



GOCBS Adoption Information

Contact Michell H. Armstrong for more information

There is a minimal fee charged to adopt a bird

There is no cost to place a bird up for adoption

- Lost and found birds will stay in foster care for two weeks while attempts are made to find the original owner before adoption.
- Birds will be offered to club members first, then to the general public with purchase of membership.
- Michell H. Armstrong will let people know through the newsletter, our webpage or announcement at the meetings, what birds are available. Applications will then be taken and she will decide on a suitable home.



Volunteers are needed for fostering. If you have a room/quarantine area and want to sign up to foster, please contact Michell H. Armstrong

Adoption fees are as follows:

\$10 - Finch	\$40 – Conure
\$10 - Parakeet	\$40 - Quaker
\$10 – Canary	\$100 - Grey
\$40 - Love Bird	\$100 - Amazon
\$40 – Parrolet	\$100 - Cockatoo
\$40 – Cockatiel	\$100 - Macaw
\$40 – Senegal	\$10 – Elderly/Handicapped ¹

For non-members wanting to adopt, and additional \$5 charge will include membership for the current year. This will not apply to finches, parakeets or canaries only.

GOCBS is not responsible for the health or behavior of birds being adopted. We encourage anyone interested in adopting a bird to have it examined by a vet and, of course, to quarantine it from other birds in the home for a minimum of a 30-day period.

¹ At the discretion of Michell H. Armstrong and Board Approval.

NOTICE REGARDING POSSIBLE ESTABLISHMENT OF AN ADOPTION-ADVISORY COMMITTEE

At the January meeting, several items were raised which were brought to the attention of the active members of the Society. In order to become a more effective asset to the metro and surrounding area of the bird community (now and in the future), some changes or updates in the way we conduct club issues and complying with its Mission Statement (See Below) may be necessary.

The Board Members of the GOCBS being pro-active in the sustainability of its goals has decided to form a 'committee' to poll the current membership on their thoughts and ideas on several issues.

1) We are looking for volunteers from our general membership to step forward and become a voice for this committee, herein referred to as The Adoption Advisory Committee. There are no special requirements – only your dedication to our Mission Statement and a few hours of your time each month. This committee is outlined as follows:

- Each member of the committee would be asked to canvass a number of our general membership to find who is interested in volunteering to help with the picking up surrendered birds and/or the fostering of these birds for the period of time in which these birds remain in our adoption program. This would be an on-going task which may involve conducting a 'home visit' to ensure the safe placement of the foster bird(s) in suitable surroundings until such time as the bird has been adopted.

We are in dire need of Foster Parents (both long and short-term), and assisting with picking up of surrendered birds, conducting home visits where deemed necessary. All too often too many birds are adopted but for whatever reason find their way back into the program; either because the parent(s) discover this bird isn't what they '*really wanted*' or the bird does not '*fit-in*' with the rest of the family. It's cases like these where home visits in advance of an adoption could reduce the number of birds being returned from what we hoped would have been their forever home.

-
- Review of our current surrender guidelines and make recommended changes, if necessary.
 - Review of our adoption guidelines and requirements and make recommended changes, if necessary.

Other items brought up at the January meeting include:

- 2) Better communication of what the GOCBS is and its mission.
- 3) Better allocation of monies to get the surrounding communities more involved through advertisement.
- 4) How to grow and maintain ACTIVE memberships by attending meetings, become involved by volunteering at our semi-annual fairs and being an active voice in the direction the GOCBS is going.

A Wise Bird Once Said, "You Can't Complain if You Never Leave the Safety of the Nest."

Volunteer!

MISSION STATEMENT:

The objectives of the Society are the study of foreign and native birds (except domestic poultry and pigeons); the dissemination of information among the members for the care, breeding and feeding of birds in captivity; the perpetuation of species that are threatened with extinction; the investigation and study of proposed and enacted legislation pertaining to aviculture; the activities to encourage and promote public interest in and an opportunity to exhibit a variety of caged birds; and the publication of matters pertaining to aviculture.

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Birds Available for Adoption

**All Adoptions and Surrendering of Birds are
TEMPORARY SUSPENDED due to COVID-19**



Green Cheek Conure

Name: Abby

Approx. Age: 14 yrs. old

Sex: Male (Sexed)

Health Issues: None.

Temperament: Steps up. He's a bit nippy but can be redirected.

Diet: ZuPreem Natural and Fruit Pellets.

Status: Ready for Adoption.



Yellow-Sided Green Cheek Conure

Name: Louis

Approx. Age: 14 yrs. old

Sex: Male (Sexed)

Health Issues: None.

Temperament: Will Step up. A little nippy but can redirect biting.

Diet: ZuPreem Natural and Fruit Pellets.

Status: Ready for Adoption.



Black-Capped Green Cheek Conure

Name: Kiwi

Approx. Age: 14 yrs. old

Sex: Male (Sexed)

Health Issues: None.

Temperament: Will Step up. Also a little nippy but can redirect biting.

Diet: ZuPreem Natural and Fruit Pellets.

Status: Ready for Adoption.



Blue-Gold McCaw

Name: Zoey

Approx. Age: 14 yrs. old

Sex: Female

Health Issues: Self-Mutilator.

Temperament: Will step up only with a towel.

Diet: ZuPreem Natural and Fruit Pellets. Unsalted nuts in shell

Fresh fruits and veggies and some people. Will bully smaller

Birds so does better with other larger birds.

Status: Ready for Adoption.



Cockatiels

Names: Queen (darker grey) Jester (lighter grey)

Approx. Ages: Nine Months

Sex: Believed both to be male

Health Issues: None Known.

Temperament: Both are skittish and do not step up, but will

tame quickly with your work.

Diet: Cockatiel Seeds

Status: Ready for Adoption.

Cockatiel Family
May be Adopted Separately
when Adoption Suspension is Lifted

Cockatiels

Names: Un-named

Approx. Ages: Mom & Dad - 3 yrs. Old Seven Babies will be one yr. old in April.

Sex: Babies – 5 Females and 2 males

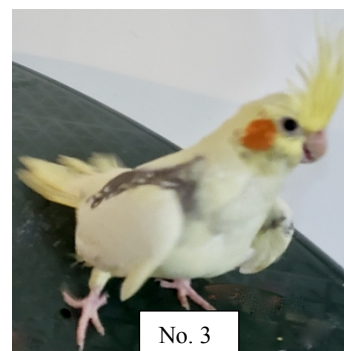
Health Issues: None Known.

Temperament: All are skittish and do not step up, but will

tame quickly and nicely with work.

Diet: Cockatiel Seeds

Status: Ready for Adoption.





No. 4



No. 5



No. 6



No. 7

Anyone interested in adopting a bird (or wishing to donate), should contact Michell H. Armstrong for additional information. Please bear in mind birds may enter our program without much notice – and may exit the same way. A specific bird may not be available when you call. **If you are looking for a specific bird species, please get your name on Michell's 'Want List'.**

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GREATER OMAHA CAGE BIRD SOCIETY

Who Needs a Bird Club Anyway?

If you keep birds as pets or raise them for a hobby, **YOU DO!**

Bird clubs are great resources for anyone interested in keeping birds. All bird owners go through similar experiences, so the resources of information about a variety of subjects can be a big help.

	Jan – Dec	July – Dec ½ price
Junior (Under 16)	\$ 12.50/yr.	\$ 6.25
Single	20.00/yr.	10.00
Family	25.00/yr.	12.50
Business Associate	25.00/yr.	12.50

Meetings are held at 3:00 pm on the 3rd Sunday of each month at the Center City Mall (42nd & Center Streets) – Suite 214, Omaha, NE.

Make Checks Payable to G.O.C.B.S. (Website: www.GreaterOmahaCageBirdSociety.org)

(Please bring your payment to a meeting or mail to: GOCBS, c/o Elsa Ashelford, 1641 Manatt Street, Lincoln, NE 68521)

2020 GOCBS Membership APPLICATION FORM

Type Membership: Junior _____ Single _____ Family _____ Business Associate _____

Date: _____ New _____ Renewal _____

Name(s): _____

Address: _____

City/State: _____ Zip Code: _____

Date(s) of Birth: Month / Day only (List all from above) _____

Home Phone: (_____) _____ Roster: Y _____ N _____ Unlisted _____

Work Phone: (_____) _____ Roster: Y _____ N _____ Unlisted _____

E-Mail Address (for Newsletter only): _____

Pet Bird(s)* _____ Do You Breed Birds: Y _____ N _____

Are You Interested in Fostering _____ Adopting _____ Quarantine Area available: Y _____ N _____

If yes, please specify Species/Size: _____

Official Use Only: Yr. _____ Pd. \$ _____ CA / CK # _____

*Please list additional birds on reverse side

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The Great Escape

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Michael Dolton/Flapping Feathers
<http://www.ParrotSpeech.com>

We had been out for a couple of hours at dinner with my son's family. After saying "Good night" outside our house, we drove our car into the garage and walked to the garage entry to our home.

I walked into the hallway and reached around the corner to turn off the burglar alarm. As I did so I briefly noted a patch of blue, which did not register until after I had put in a code to stop the sounding of the alarm system annunciator. As the noise ceased my attention focused on our leather sofa in our family room.

Double take. Sitting on the top of the sofa back I saw our macaw, Arielle. She looked at me as if to say, "Well, I was just waiting here for you to return." I lifted her and placed her back in her house. The dog, Riley, was a short distance away from the sofa in his family room crate.

In checking the house, Arielle had not done any major damage. There was evidence that she had been behind the lamp table and been "nesting" in the bird cage covers that we store there when not in use. She apparently became bored

and moved to the adjacent basket that holds old newspapers. She had shredded a couple of pages. I don't know whether she had wandered over to Riley to taunt him in his crate or not.

Arielle had apparently pulled herself to the top of the leather sofa without damaging the leather. She did not shred her mom's blanket which the macaw may have used to get from the seat to the sofa back. The blanket had fallen back to the seat. In all of the house she had not done any damage other than the few papers she shredded. She left no soiling anywhere in the house outside her cage other than all the pelleted food that was on the floor near the entry.

How did she get out? She is very mechanically inclined and it took several steps for her to exit her house. Apparently, I accidentally left a special click-link loose on the food-bowl door; the link is a secondary means to keep her inside. She was able to twist and rotate the closing bar and simultaneously pull it back to disable the food-door mechanism. Then, knowing that her food-bowl door was free to swing open, she

pushed her food bowl away from the holding bars. The bowl exited the structure with a few additional pushes and dropped to the floor spilling

pellets. Once the bowl was displaced, she was free to squeeze through the opening. It was a cinch to climb down the side of her cage and drop to the floor.

This is a quite involved escape procedure, and you have to respect her native intelligence. She is a civilized bird, and I was happy to find that while she was mischievous, she had done no damage to anything in the house. "Girls just want to have fun!"

That's my bird girl!



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Pamela Clark, CPBC

The Parrot Steward Blog



Risk Factors for Feather Damaging Behavior

I had the honor last summer of listening to Dr. Susan G. Friedman give a lecture on *control*. What she had to say blew my mind and I continue to be as excited today by the ideas presented then – not only because what I heard was new, but because they reverberated within me as truth.



Susan with my dog Rika
To paraphrase what Dr. Friedman had to say:

Behavior is the way that we control outcomes. When we behave, we move the environment in such a way that we are able to access reinforcers (things we value) and escape aversives (things we want to avoid).

When we, or any animal, performs a behavior, it is like tossing a stone into a river. A ripple is created. There is no way not to create a ripple when tossing the stone, just like there is no way not to influence the environment when we behave.

*Learning is what we were born to do and the ability to learn is a product of natural selection. It is in our nature to control our outcomes. Therefore, the need for control is a part of our biology. There is a biological need for control. Therefore, **control is a primary reinforcer**, as vital to our parrot's quality of life as food or water.*

Control is a Biological Need

We know that all animals exercise control by making choices. I have argued for years that by increasing the number of choices that our parrots are able to make we are increasing their quality of life.

Lauren A. Leotti and her co-authors expand upon this idea by saying, "Belief in one's ability to exert control over the environment and to produce desired results is essential for an individual's well-being. It has been repeatedly argued that the perception of control is not only desirable, but it is likely a psychological and biological necessity." They go on to state that "the restriction of choice is aversive." (Leotti, 2010)

Lack of Control is Aversive

Not only is it aversive, it can result in the condition of *learned helplessness*. This is a state of behavior in which the animal stops even trying to make choices. How many times have we described a parrot as a "perch potato?" The perch potato is manifesting a version of learned helplessness.



Expanding upon this idea, they write: "In the absence of other stressors, however, the removal of choice, in and of itself, can be very stressful. It has been found that

the restriction of behaviors, particularly behaviors that are highly valued by a species, contributes to behavioral and physiological manifestations of stress. It seems that the aversive effects of captivity may depend upon the extent to which behavioral choices have been reduced relative to what could be performed in the natural environment.” (Leotti, 2010)

New Perceptions



In the past few years, I have come to see our parrot-keeping practices in a new light. We have taken flighted spirits, clipped their wings, and put them in cages. Many parrots spend all of their time in their cage, or have at most, one or two hours out each day. We have taken away their liberty, which is essential for exercising choice.

If we kept dogs in a similar manner, rendering them unable to move in a way natural to them and keeping them in kennels for 22 hours every day, it would be considered abuse. However, these practices are still commonplace in the parrot world, rarely being brought into question. We appear unable to judge the inappropriateness of these practices since they have been accepted as normal for so long.



The Problem with Conventional Wisdom

The explanation for this lies in the phenomenon called *conventional wisdom*. Conventional wisdom is a collection of beliefs that are convenient and comfortable to people, such that they are able to resist facts that might diminish those very beliefs. (Wikipedia, 2019) I once heard someone say: *A belief is an emotional commitment to an idea. As soon as you have a belief, you are automatically in denial in regards to any information that comes to you to the contrary.*

Peter Hitchens Quote

Our conventional wisdom, when it comes to our companion parrots, is causing them harm. Dr. Friedman stated in her presentation, "A lack of control is a major risk factor for feather damaging behavior." I could not agree more.

Feather Damaging Behavior

I have specialized in helping clients whose birds damage their feathers since 1996 and have given considerable thought to the causes. The list of *non-medical* causes I compiled years ago in an article for the World Parrot Trust included (1) inappropriate diet, (2) chronic stress or anxiety, (3) increased production of reproductive hormones, (4) lack of independent play skills that leads to boredom or over-dependence on the owner, (5) inadequate bathing opportunities, (6) lack of adequate rest, (7) insufficient exercise, (8) insufficient opportunity for learning and making choices, (9) lack of foraging and other "discovery" opportunities, (10) lack of access to fresh air and sunshine, and (11) foreign substances on feathers or exposure to toxic materials, such as cigarette smoke.

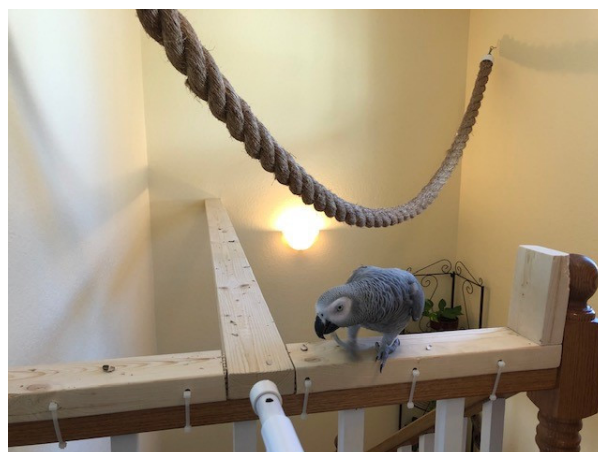
Today, my list reads as follows:

- Chronic stress resulting from lack of choice making opportunities, especially as this relates to natural behaviors (foraging, flying, bathing, problem solving, enjoying fresh air and sunshine), and an overall lack of liberty and control
- Inappropriate diet
- Increased production of reproductive hormones
- Inferior juvenile rearing conditions

I had two experiences this past year that appear to support my new view. Two female greys that I raised close to 20 years ago needed a change of homes. One came back to me to stay and the other went to a client of mine. Both greys had previously enjoyed really good homes – they had large cages, were flighted, ate nutritious diets, got plenty of enrichment, and had access to outdoor aviaries. However, they both spent too many hours in their cages.

One of the New Environments

Both had extensive feather damage over their torsos at the time of rehoming. Now, both are fully feathered. In their current homes, they still have cages, but they enjoy a great deal more liberty, which results in the ability to make choices at an exponential rate. Both birds also had the advantage of excellent early rearing experiences and wonderful first homes. It appears that greater control over choices was the one factor that was significantly different in these new homes.



Unethical Practices Harm Us as Well

Given the above, it should be clear that the *typical* manner in which we keep parrots is destructive to their physical and psychological health. However, it harms us as well.

How are we harmed by our own behavior? We fail to appreciate that depriving a captive parrot of the ability to move around at choice, to fly, has an ethical component. Therefore, we are able to behave unethically while still maintaining a positive self-image.

However, there *are* many who are uncomfortable on some level. A good many clients have confided to me that they feel terrible that their parrots live in cages and display behaviors consistent with learned helplessness. This requires action.

Feasible Changes



Conventional wisdom is resistant to change. So, how can we begin? Where do we start?

Grand sweeping gestures are prone to failure. It is not feasible to abandon the use of cages or release them all out "into the wild."

This is a complex subject and behavior is a *study of one*. This true both for us and our birds. What is possible in one home may not be possible in another.

However, as Kurtyca suggests, "...although we cannot offer them complete control over all aspects of their environment, perhaps by offering choices within the confines of captivity, we can give some small amount of control, and thus increase their wellbeing." (Kurtycz, 2015)

"One of the putative sources of stress in captivity is interference with or prevention of animals' engagement in species-typical behaviors for which they appear to have a "behavioral need." (Morgan, 2006)

Species-typical Behaviors

Might this be the best place to begin our efforts? Species-typical behaviors for parrots include flying, foraging and problem solving, social interactivity, perching up high, chewing wood and other materials, bathing, interacting with the natural environment, and mating and rearing young.

It is only the last that we cannot afford to encourage in the companion parrot home. When we have done so in the past, most often the results have been disastrous.

Flight

As I have argued many times, wings should never be clipped unless absolutely necessary and certainly not for human convenience. Instead, our own homes and behavior must be modified in order to support their flighted status.

Foraging and Other Enrichment

If a parrot did not learn to forage when young, he will not understand the concept of hidden food. This then will need to be patiently taught. In regards to other enrichment, a wide variety of chewable items can be provided – cloth, palm frond toys, wood that is easy to chew, cardboard and paper, bells. A parrot regains a bit of control over his environment when he can choose the items with which he interacts.

The Natural Environment

I no longer regard as optional the provision of a *safe* space outdoors where a parrot can enjoy the natural environment. Notice that I used italics for the word “safe.”

I did so because there are problems with putting birds outdoors in carriers or cages. The small dimensions of both may cause stress, since the parrot perceives a lack of ability for escape should a predator be seen. The width of cage bars could allow a predator access to the parrot. Both must be used only with close supervision.

An aviary is, of course, the ideal. However, if this is not possible, other options must be considered. The stimulation of natural sunshine and breezes not only encourages good psychological health, the exposure to sunlight encourages good physical health.

Social Connectivity

We can offer a captive parrot greater control over his social interactions when we watch his body language carefully and then create greater distance if the signs indicate that this is his desire. We can decrease his stress by leaving plenty of room between the cages if multiple parrots of different species reside in one home.

We might also call into question the practice of keeping a single parrot. They are flocking creatures and, while they might be flexible enough to regard us and our other pets as a member of their flock, a single parrot often benefits from another bird in the home. No one should, however, get another parrot unless they *want* one.

Access to Height



We can increase his perception of control by allowing him to perch up high, where he feels safer. This is accomplished by installing hanging perches in the ceiling.

Placing area rugs below will contain the mess, and reinforcing cued behaviors will ensure that you can retrieve him.

Training Offers Control

One of the best ways we can give back control to a parrot is to live as a trainer, by providing frequent opportunities for earning reinforcers. Positive reinforcement training is the gold standard for behavior change. It provides enrichment. It makes our lives easier. It helps us learn to read body language.

There are many reasons to train a parrot. However, the greatest of these is that it affords the parrot a sense of *control*. He has control over his ability to access the things he desires. Here are a few specific things you might begin to do:

- Begin to teach specific behaviors, like targeting.
- Offer your parrot a reinforcer (small piece of preferred food) for every cued behavior.
- Embrace the **SMART x 50** approach to encouraging desirable behavior.

Kathy Sdao, ACAAB, owns [Bright Spot Dog Training](#) and developed the SMART x 50 program. Although published for dogs, this can easily be applied to parrot behavior. SMART is the acronym for See, Mark And Reward Training. The numeral 50 refers to the goal of dispensing 50 reinforcers a day. (I think this amount may be excessive for a parrot, unless you can factor in some healthy choices.)

SMART x 50

This program encourages owners to get into the habit of awareness regarding the desirable behaviors that their parrots perform on a daily basis. It relies on the assumption that every bird already performs many desirable behaviors during the

course of any day and that we can strengthen these and increase quality of life for our birds in the process.

These are the steps:

- Count out 50 very small (no bigger than ½ the size of a pine nut), desirable treats.
- Put these in a pocket or small container for easy access.
- When you see or hear your parrot perform a cute or desirable behavior, mark this with one distinct word, such as "Yes!" (Examples: desirable noises, singing, interacting with enrichment, responding to cues such as "step up.")
- Deliver the treat.
- Use up to 50 treats a day, but don't feel badly if 10 are all you are able to dispense.

In using this, I have seen a distinct change in all of my animals. They become more interactive and enthusiastic in their demeanor. And, don't be surprised if yours begin to toss out some new behaviors, just to see if those might also earn something.

The Next Decade

Jacques Deval once wrote "God loved the birds and invented trees. Man loved the birds and invented cages."

Although true, I think this is a horrible little quote. Perhaps I find it so because of the truth he spoke. Let's put the lie to those words in the next decade and strive for practices that allow for more liberty and control for our parrots. Each of us can just take one reasonable, do-able step at a time.

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Parrots and Stress Bars

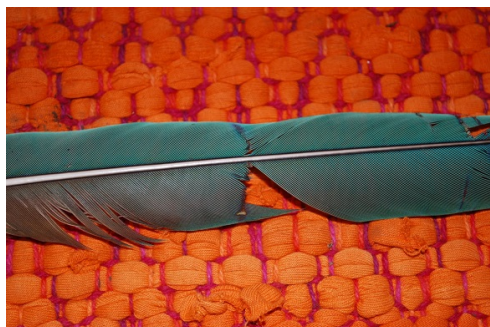
Published on Friday, 2nd August 2019
Filed under [Parrot Health & Safety](#)

It is raining feathers in my house. I am so excited to report that Blu Lu the Blue-throated Macaw from the [Bird Endowment](#) is molting. That may seem like a silly thing to celebrate. Let me explain why I am so happy.

Blu Lu had a rough start in life. She was rejected by her parents. This meant she likely did not get fed as frequently or as much as she needed during those critical early weeks of development. When [baby Parrots](#) miss feedings, become ill or are otherwise compromised it shows.

One place where it becomes very evident is in their feathers. What is often observed when conditions are poor and a feather is growing in is what is known as a stress bar. The bar is a line that is visible across the feather. This line represents a weak spot in the feather. Without adequate nutrition the feather did not development properly at that spot.

The drawback to stress bars is that the feather is very vulnerable at this line. Many feathers break at the stress bar. Tail feathers and primary feathers (wing feathers) need the support of surrounding feathers to grow successfully. Without support they too can break.



Blue Lu did break a few tail feathers close to the base of her tail due to stress bars. And it will be important to keep an eye on her new growing tail

feathers. New feathers initially have a blood and nerve supply. If one of the growing feathers were to break it could bleed and be painful.

In most cases a little pressure can stop the bleeding, but if you are unsure what to do when a blood feather breaks, I do highly recommend you visit your avian veterinarian. You can find an avian at [The Association of Avian Veterinarians](#) website.

Fortunately, once she was rejected by her parents Blu Lu was well taken care of by caring humans and her feather growth from then on improved considerably. However, this first molt is a welcomed one. It means she will soon have a brand-new set of very healthy feathers. Just one single broken flight feather can dramatically effect flight skills. It is

often a matter of pride for many professional bird trainers that their birds are in perfect feather. It is a reflection of excellent care.

Blu Lu is already pretty stunning. But I can't wait for her new spring wardrobe!

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For quality information on Parrot training visit <https://www.goodbirdinc.com/>

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This was originally published on Barbara's blog in 2011.

For more information on Parrot health and safety please [click here](#).

Find products to help your Parrot's feathers [here](#).

Links

The first link below talks about how a New Delhi woman transforms paper and epoxy into bird sculptures. The second link contains sculptures for sale.

<https://www.atlasobscura.com/articles/paper-bird-sculptures-new-delhi>

<https://www.etsy.com/shop/nvillustration>

This third link is about fun things you can do with your bird during the COVID-19 Pandemic.

<https://lafeber.com/pet-birds/fun-things-to-do-with-your-bird-at-home/>

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Wanted

Your Attendance at meetings, volunteering your services to ensure our club remains a viable and strong organization within our communities in order to provide a safe haven for our feathered friends and a source of information and help for their parents.

Articles for the Newsletter About Your Birds, New Ideas and requests for article reprints.

For Sale

McCaws: Female Harlequin, 26 yrs. old (Emory); Female Blue & Gold, 24 yrs. old (Boomer); Male Green-Winged, 20 yrs. old (Blaze). All come with a cage, toys and food. \$1,500 each. If interested, call Brandi for details at: (402) 708.4492.

Two pair of one-year old Gouldian Finches. Ready for breeding. Females are black headed; males are red headed. \$75 ea. bird. Contact Ken at (402) 314.1575 or e-mail him at: ken.majors@gmail.com

Services

CARPOOLING: Anyone interested in carpooling from the Lincoln, NE area to Omaha, NE to attend the GOCBS monthly meetings should contact Elsa at (402) 309-0683, or e-mail her at: pandora1641@yahoo.com

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King-size foundation (2 twins). Like New. You haul. Contact George at: george.lav@icloud.com

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**42nd & Center Streets
Omaha, NE - - Suite 214**

3:00 p.m.

Hope to See You There!

❖ If you bring your bird to a meeting for wing clipping, please use the room to the left as you enter the meeting room. 'Flighted' birds are not permitted in the meeting area.

❖ Please ensure any droppings your bird may decide to 'gift' while visiting are thoroughly cleaned off chair backs and the carpeting before you leave.